car. ‘Give it to the children, they will like it,’ she said. She wasn’t an easy person to say no to!

And yet, she was mercurial and moody, appearing almost bipolar at times. She could be warm and caring (every Puja she sends me a kurta), but also ferocious and short-tempered. In 2012, she agreed to do a show with us in Kolkata’s Town Hall on the completion of one year of the Trinamool Congress government. Our deputy editor at CNN-IBN, Sagarika Ghose, was anchoring the programme. When we began recording, Mamata’s mood appeared to be cheery. Barely ten minutes into the show, her attitude swung dramatically. A student asked her about her handling of the Park Street rape. It was enough for Mamata to flip. ‘You are a Maoist, this audience is full of Maoists,’ she shouted in a manic manner and walked out, with Sagarika struggling to hold her back.

A year before, I had an even more bizarre experience when we chose Mamata as the CNN-IBN Politician of the Year for her stunning achievement in dismantling the left citadel in Bengal. Just a day before the function, Mamata rang me up to say that she would not attend. ‘I will not share a stage with Anna Hazare,’ she said emphatically. Anna had been chosen as the Indian of the Year for being the mascot of the anti-corruption movement. I pleaded with Mamata and promised her we would give away her award first so that she wouldn’t have to encounter Anna. She relented.

The next evening, she entered the Taj Palace Durbar Hall with a large contingent of Trinamool MPs. She seemed happy at all the attention being showered on her. We had tried to keep Anna away from her in a room next to the hall but couldn’t hold him there for long. The moment he entered and their paths crossed, Mamata blew a fuse. ‘You have not kept your promise, Rajdeep—I am leaving,’ she hollered. Dressed in my bandhgala, I ran after her right across the lobby of the five-star hotel, pleading with her to come back. Finally, as she was driving off in her blue Maruti, at the gate, I almost physically pulled her out. With a little help from Trinamool MP, Dinesh Trivedi, we escorted her back to the award ceremony. She received the award, gave a brief speech, smiled for the cameras and left. I don’t think the Taj has ever seen a scene quite like that.